

Translation Checking Steps: Training Guide

Training Goals:

1. The audience will understand that:

- The four checking steps help to ensure the accuracy of the translation draft.
- The checking steps must be done separately and in order.
- The checking steps should include as many checkers and as many resources as possible.
- The Key Word Check is a necessary, focused check on the accuracy and consistency of difficult and theological concepts.

2. The audience will be able to:

- Use the four checking steps to improve the quality of their draft (Checking Steps Exercise).
- Identify the key words in a passage and explain why they are key words (Key Words Exercise).

Estimated Time: 45-90 min. checking steps, 45-60 min. Key Word Check (multiple sessions recommended). **Note:** Add 15-30 min. if using Optional Exercise (Translate Key Words List).

Materials: ✓ Slides: Translation Checking Steps - Slides (Optional)
✓ Eight Steps for Workshops (from Translation Drafting Steps session)
✓ **Luke 17:11-19 ULB, or the source text passage used for drafting practice**
✓ **Blind drafts** from Translation Drafting Steps session (will be used in later sessions also)
✓ **Key Words Exercise** (or Luke 17 in the source text; 1 copy for each person)
✓ **Pens or highlighters** (1 for each person)
✓ **White board and markers** (Recommended)

Introduction: Remember, the Eight-Step translation process is designed to create **meaning-based translations**. The process focuses the translator on **meaningful, natural wording first, then applies careful checking to ensure accuracy and completeness**.

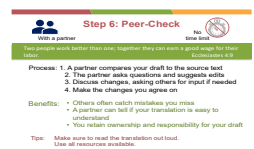
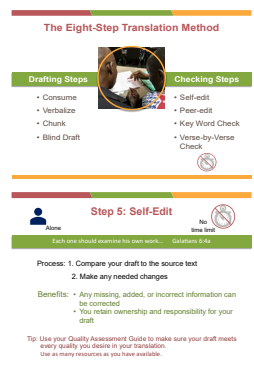
The Four Checking Steps

The next four steps are checking steps. **Timing does NOT matter in these steps. Translators can take as long as they need to make changes.**

Step 5: Self-Edit – (Alone) Translators will open the source text and look at it again. They will compare what they have written to the source text and make any needed changes. They should make sure that everything is included and correct—checking details, key words, and key terms. They should check for correct and consistent spelling, and correct punctuation. They will also use the standards on their [*Quality Assessment Guide*](#) and other checking resources to help them check their own work. (These resources will be explained in another session.) Finally, translators should add verse numbers and make sure any handwritten work is easy to read.

Step 6: Peer-Check – (With a partner) Another member of the team will read the draft, looking for the same things mentioned in Self-Edit. The partner should compare the translation to the source text to make sure that nothing is missing or incorrect, and that everything is clear. The translator and partner should sit together while the partner reads the translation aloud and offers suggestions. Only the translator should make changes as needed to the draft.

Share Ecclesiastes 4:9-10 on the benefits of working with a partner, or 1 Corinthians 12:12–14 on God's design of one body with many parts.



Here are some important points to remember:

- Peer checkers are not looking for a word-for-word translation; they are looking to make sure that the **AUTHOR'S INTENDED MEANING** is communicated. Peer editors should remember to use the **Quality Assessment Guide** as their standard. Here are some things they are looking for:
 - Is anything missing? Is anything added?
 - Is the draft natural and smooth?
 - Does it sound good in the target language? Is it pleasing to hear when it is read out loud?
 - Is it clear and understandable?
 - Is it accurate?
 - Are all the details there?
 - Are the spelling and punctuation correct?
- The partner (peer checker) should ask questions and make suggestions about the translator's work. However, the translator is the one who will make changes to their own translation. The peer checker should not change things.
- If the two cannot agree on changes, they should get help from their other team members.

Remember that each person will be a peer checker for others on the team.

Step 7: Key Word Check – (With a new partner) There are three parts to this check:

- First, the translator will work with a new partner to read the passage in the source text and mark key words and terms. They should be sure to include Divine Familiar Terms on their list.

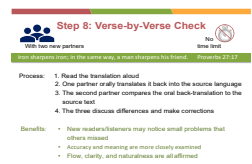
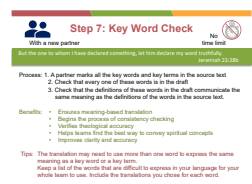
Note: A **key term** is a word that has spiritual meaning (examples: Holy Spirit [e.g., in Luke 3:22], glory, sanctification). These words are important throughout the whole Bible. A **key word** is a word that is important to the meaning of the sentence (examples: names; verbs; connecting words like therefore, because, so [e.g., in Luke 6:7]).

- Second, the partner should ask the translator if these words and terms are included in the draft. The translator will answer “yes” or “no.” If there are several “no” answers, they should not move forward. Instead, the translator will repeat the Self-Edit and Peer-Check steps.
- Third, if all the key words and terms are in the translated text (or only one or two are missing, and they can be added easily), the pair will move on by verifying each key word and term with these questions: “What is the definition of the word?” “Was the original meaning of this word accurately communicated in the translation?” A resource called **Translation Words** will help with this step. This resource will be discussed in another session.

Note: For some languages, the translator may have to re-draft the chunk using a blind draft to ensure that the natural flow of the translation is preserved.

The Key Word Check is essential to ensuring that the translation is a clear, meaning-based translation. Key words and terms are also part of consistency checking for the translation, which is necessary for high quality. Since key words and terms are so significant, we will discuss them in more detail after the team practices the Eight Steps.

Step 8: Verse-by-Verse Check – (With two new partners as checkers) The translator will read the translation aloud to both checkers, one verse at a time. The first checker will translate each verse aloud back into the source language, while the second



checker looks at the source text and listens to make sure that the translation is accurate and complete, marking any differences. The group should remember that the back-translation will not be word-for-word. They are checking that the translation communicates the same meaning as the source text and that nothing is missing. The group will then discuss these differences and determine if changes need to be made. They should use all available resources. The two partners should ask any questions they have and suggest edits that they feel are needed.

This is the last check, so if anything is missing, incorrect, or unclear, they should work together so they know what to edit or add. They will work until everyone is satisfied that the translation meets the *Quality Assessment Guide* that the translation team agreed on.

If many mistakes are found, the translator should start by going back to step 5, and the team will redo all the checking steps.

The translators should involve as many different team members at different steps as possible, and be involved themselves, so that many translators are making suggestions for improving the quality of each other's translations. During the checking steps, translators will use all resources available and make all changes that are needed. If they are ever stuck, they should pray and ask God for guidance. They can also ask others for help. Some things may not be fixed in one conversation or at one event, and may require involving others for improvement.



Exercise: Four Checking Steps

Have each person take out their blind drafts from the Four Drafting Steps session. Each person should also have a copy of Luke 17:11-19 in their source text. They may use the handout “Eight Steps for Workshops” to help them.

Have the team members use the checking steps to check their translation of Luke 17:11–19, and their translation of “Eight Steps for Workshops.” (If they had time to translate “Eight Steps for Workshops,” it will be available as a helpful reference in their team throughout the translation process.) They should work through steps 5–8 together.

Allow about 1 hour for this exercise. Then, discuss with the whole group.



Ask: What do you think will happen if you skip any of these steps?

Be ready to give examples for reinforcement. Help the team understand that **skipping steps will actually result in more work!**

Potential consequences when skipping steps:

- Without **Self-Edit**—Lost ownership; responsibility for error correction is pushed on to others who may be hesitant to correct; more work in steps 6–8 that will make the process take longer
- Without **Peer-Check**—Key words and phrases are lost, causing others in later steps to question quality; naturalness is not affirmed; lost opportunity to build partnership and camaraderie for future steps



- **Without Key Word Check**—Lack of consistency in key terms and key words; theological misunderstandings because key terms or key words were not translated properly
- **Without Verse-by-Verse Check**—This step is a catch-all for anything that was missed; clarity, accuracy, naturalness, flow, conciseness, key words, and understanding are all confirmed at this check. If skipped, whole verses may be missing, or the meaning may be unclear.

Some trainers use the illustration of raising crops. There are many steps to growing a good crop: preparing the ground, planting at the correct time, planting at the correct depth, regular weeding, etc. If any steps are missed, workers will still get a crop, but it will not be as good as it is when every step is followed correctly.

Key Word Check

Step 7 of the Eight Steps process is the Key Word Check. Translators should have a good understanding of what a key word is, as well as how to check key words, in order to do Step 7 properly.

Ask: How would you define a key word?

List answers on white board or easel. If they give examples, put those in a separate list. Point out that these might not be single words—for example, “Holy Spirit.”

Explain: A key word is:

- a word that has a strong impact on the overall meaning of the passage
- an abstract word
- a spiritual term, or
- a word that is repeated throughout a section of Scripture for emphasis

(Examples of repeated words include “immediately” in Mark, or “joy” & “rejoice” in Philippians.)

Spiritual terms may be profound concepts, such as “redemption,” or simpler terms such as Divine Familial (family) Terms. (Divine Familial Terms will be explained in another session. These are terms such as “Father” and “Son” used to describe the relationship between God the Father and his Son, Jesus.) All Divine Familial Terms should be included in a key word list because of their impact on meaning.

Note: Some teams include all **names of people and places** in their key word list, and others do not. Historically, not all of these are included, but including them is not wrong; it is merely a preference. Some teams also include **all words that have no direct translation in their language**. Teams may keep a list of these words and how they chose to express them in the translation. Then, all the translators can use the list for reference during translation.

Ask: When thinking about the Eight Steps process, are there other steps where you might find errors in key words?

Both Self-Edit and Peer-Check provide opportunities to find these errors.

Even though there are two previous steps where errors could be caught in key words, this step is essential because it concentrates the checking to specifically target words that express spiritual concepts.



Ask: Why do you think these words and phrases should be targeted in this separate checking step?

Some of these words are uncommon, or hard to translate. There may not be a precise equivalent for them in every language, so they may need to be carefully considered, or even created. This check is the beginning of consistency checking—making sure that these ideas are clear across your entire translation.

Key words and terms are an essential part of creating a meaning-based translation. If these concepts are not translated accurately and consistently, the translation will not be able to accurately or clearly communicate the meaning of the original message.

Ask: What do you think are key words in John 3:16?

Have the team look the verse over and suggest key words. Put those on the board.

For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him will not perish but have eternal life.

The list should include God, loved, world, only, Son, believes, perish, eternal life.

Explain: If any of these words are mis-translated or skipped, there would be an inaccurate and potentially harmful translation.

Consider the complex meaning of “perish” in this passage.

Ask:

- What does the word “perish” mean in this passage?
- Would it be OK to use a word that means “die”? Why or why not?

Excerpt from *Translation Words* for discussion:

The term “perish” means to die or be destroyed, usually as the result of violence or other disaster.

- The word “perish” can also be a metaphor for being punished in hell either presently or in the future.
- Something that is “imperishable” will never perish.

Translation Suggestions:

- Depending on the context, ways to translate this term could include “die” or “be destroyed” or “be punished in hell” or “will be punished in hell.”
- When perish is a metaphor, make sure that the translation of “perish” does not only mean “cease to exist.”

Note: The trainer may also want to discuss what the term “world” means in this passage: Does it refer to all of creation? –to all living beings? etc.

Exercise: Key Words

Purpose: Use this exercise to guide the team to understand how to choose key words and terms from a passage.

Process: Pass out Luke 17 in the source language. Have participants work in pairs to read through the passage and highlight all words they think are key words. If you are training multiple languages and will have internet, participants may access the ULB in their language for the exercise and use pen and paper to write down the key words.

Remind the teams/partners to work together and to be ready to explain their choices of words. Allow about 15 minutes for this exercise. After the time, gather the groups together to discuss.

Try it

Luke 17

Ask: Do you think everyone’s list will be the same?

The team should quickly recognize that their lists won’t be exactly the same.

Discuss

Are the lists the same?

Are some words on everyone’s lists? Why the differences?

Explain: Choosing key words and terms is not an exact process, and it is OK for there to be some variance.

Ask: Do you think that some words will be the same on everyone's list?

The team should quickly recognize that yes, some words will be the same.

Explain: Some words are essential and should be on every list.

Have the team compare their lists and explain their choices as needed.

Ask: What did you learn from the exercise?

Optional Exercise: Translate Key Words List

If the team is bilingual, you can have them do the added step of translating their key word list for Luke 17 into their heart language.

Explain: When translators do the Key Word Check, they should work together to choose their own words just as the team has done in this exercise. Although this is not a timed step, if they take longer than 20-30 minutes for a chapter, they may be analyzing too much. They need to know that a longer list of key words does not always mean more clarity and precision. Translators should be careful not to assume that every word is key to the meaning and emphasis of the passage.

Ask: What should translators do once they have made their list of key words and key terms?

What to do with the key word list

1. Check translation for each key word.
2. Discuss difficult words and choose how to translate.
3. Create list to be used by all translators.

The team should be able to explain how each word is checked in the new translation to make sure they are all represented.

Explain: There are three things that translators should do once they have made their list of key words.

1. Compare their new translation with the source text and make sure each word is represented. Some words or terms may take more than one word to express the same meaning in the target language.
2. If a word doesn't exist in their language (as often happens), they should discuss ways to convey the meaning. They can use resources like **Translation Words** to get a better idea of what the word means, or **Translation Notes** to see what other translators have done. Sometimes a new word can be created, or several words can be joined to communicate the meaning of one word. Sometimes the word can be borrowed from the source text or transliterated.
3. If the team decides to communicate a key word or term in a new way, they should make a list for everyone to use as they continue translating. This will help them to be consistent as a team. (They should include the names of people and places here, if they are checking those as key words.)

Review of Important Points:

- A key word is a word or phrase that carries significant meaning in the passage; a spiritual or abstract term; or a repeated word. It is often a word or phrase that is hard to translate because the meaning is complex. In that case, it can be difficult to find a precise equivalent across languages.
- It is important to check key words and terms separately from other steps.
- Choosing key words and terms for a passage should be a partner (or group) exercise.
- This check helps to achieve an accurate translation.

Confirm:

1. The audience understands that:

- ☐ The four checking steps help to ensure the accuracy of the translation draft.
- ☐ The checking steps must be done separately and in order.
- ☐ The checking steps should include as many checkers and as many resources as possible.
- ☐ The Key Word Check is a necessary, focused check on the accuracy and consistency of difficult and theological concepts.

2. The audience is able to:

- ☐ Use the four checking steps to improve the quality of their draft (Checking Steps Exercise).
- ☐ Identify the key words in a passage and explain why they are key words (Key Words Exercise).



Key Words Exercise

Instructions: Read through the chapter and mark every word that you think is a key word. Keep in mind the definition of a key word:

- a word that has a strong impact on the meaning of the passage
- an abstract word
- a spiritual term
- a repeated word.

Remember that a key word can be a group of words.

Luke 17 ULB

¹ Jesus said to his disciples, "It is certain there will be stumbling blocks, but woe to that person through whom they come! ² It would be better for him if a millstone were hung around his neck and he were thrown into the sea than that he should cause one of these little ones to stumble. ³ Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him, and if he repents, forgive him. ⁴ If he sins against you seven times in the day, and seven times returns to you, saying, 'I repent,' you must forgive him!"

⁵ The apostles said to the Lord, "Increase our faith."

⁶ The Lord said, "If you had faith like a mustard seed, you would say to this mulberry tree, 'Be uprooted, and be planted in the sea,' and it would obey you. ⁷ But which of you, who has a servant plowing or keeping sheep, will say to him when he has come in from the field, 'Come immediately and sit down to eat'? ⁸ Will he not say to him, 'Prepare something for me to eat, and put a belt around your clothes and serve me until I have finished eating and drinking. Then afterward you will eat and drink'? ⁹ He does not thank the servant because he did the things that were commanded, does he? ¹⁰ Even so you also, when you have done everything that you are commanded, should say, 'We are unworthy servants. We have only done what we ought to do.'"

¹¹ It came about that as he traveled to Jerusalem, he went along the border between Samaria and Galilee. ¹² As he entered into a certain village, there he was met by ten men who were lepers. They stood far away from him ¹³ and they lifted up their voices, saying, "Jesus, Master, have mercy on us."

¹⁴ When he saw them, he said to them, "Go and show yourselves to the priests." As they went away they were cleansed. ¹⁵ When one of them saw that he was healed, he turned back, with a

Key Words Exercise

loud voice glorifying God. ¹⁶ He fell on his face at Jesus' feet, giving him thanks. Now he was a Samaritan. ¹⁷ Then Jesus said, "Were not the ten cleansed? Where are the nine?" ¹⁸ Were there no others who returned to give glory to God, except this foreigner?" ¹⁹ He said to him, "Arise, and go. Your faith has made you well."

²⁰ Being asked by the Pharisees when the kingdom of God would come, Jesus answered them and said, "The kingdom of God does not come with careful observing. ²¹ Neither will they say, 'Look, here it is!' or, 'There it is!' For look, the kingdom of God is within you."

²² He said to the disciples, "The days are coming when you will desire to see one of the days of the Son of Man, but you will not see it. ²³ Then they will say to you, 'Look, there! Look, here!' But do not go out or run after them, ²⁴ for as the lightning shines brightly when it flashes from one part of the sky to another part of the sky, so will the Son of Man be in his day. ²⁵ But first he must suffer many things and be rejected by this generation. ²⁶ As it happened in the days of Noah, even so will it also happen in the days of the Son of Man.

²⁷ They ate, they drank, they married, and they were given in marriage until the day that Noah entered into the ark—and the flood came and destroyed them all. ²⁸ In the same way, even as it happened in the days of Lot—they were eating and drinking, buying and selling, planting and building. ²⁹ But in the day that Lot went out from Sodom, it rained fire and sulfur from heaven and destroyed them all. ³⁰ After the same manner it will be in the day that the Son of Man is revealed. ³¹ In that day let him who is on the housetop not go down to get his goods out of the house, and in the same way let him who is in the field not return.

³² Remember Lot's wife. ³³ Whoever seeks to gain his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life will save it. ³⁴ I tell you, in that night there will be two people in one bed. One will be taken, and the other will be left. ³⁵ There will be two women grinding grain together. One will be taken, and the other will be left." ³⁶ ¹

³⁷ They asked him, "Where, Lord?"

He said to them, "Where there is a body, there will the vultures also be gathered together."